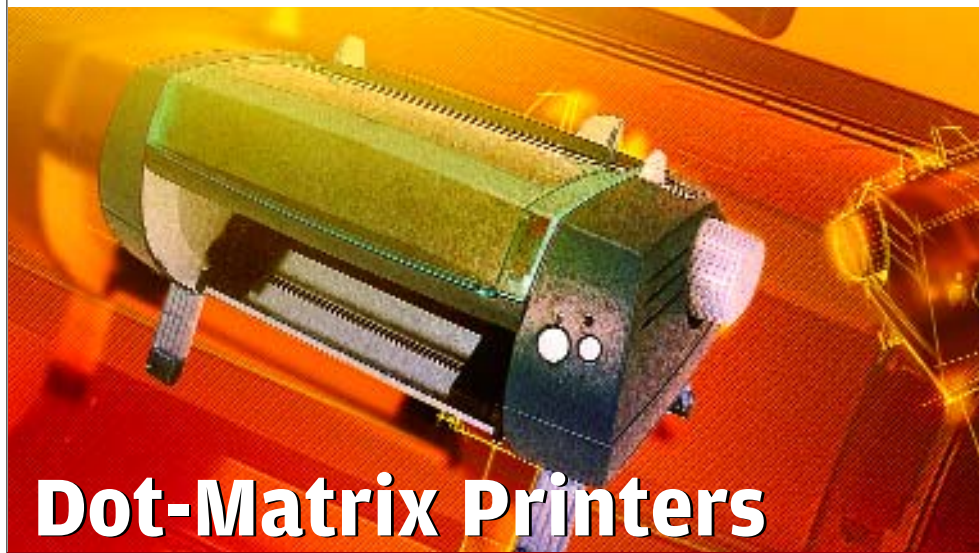




Dot-Matrix Printers

With the evolution of inkjet and laser printing technologies, experts had predicted the death of the dot matrix printer a long time ago. However, though these printers have moved out of the home environment, they have settled into their own niche and are far from being extinct.

The fact is that no other printing technology is more suitable for printing in bulk—especially in the area of billing.

Though inkjets and laserjets are much better when it comes to aspects such as print quality and speed, the low running costs and reliability of a dot matrix printer makes it a dependable choice for very large, average-quality print jobs.

What To Look At

1. **Front Panel:** You should see buttons to power on the unit, load paper, pause printing, select a font, etc.
2. **Head:** The printer head consists of either nine or 24 pins that hit the paper through the ribbon to create the image on the paper. 24-pin printers provide better quality than 9-pin printers.
3. **Ribbon:** The ribbon is a nylon strip impregnated with ink that gets transferred to the paper whenever the pins strike it. The replacement of a ribbon is simple as well as cheap.
4. **Roller:** The roller has sensors attached to it, which detect the paper. The roller pulls the paper into the printer.



Buying Tips

- ✓ **NUMBER OF PINS:** Here, pins refer to the metal pins on the printer head. Since every character or image is made up of dots, the more the number of pins, the better the print quality. There are two options to choose from—nine pins and 24 pins. Opt for a 24-pin print head as far as possible, since it will provide better print quality.
- ✓ **BUFFER:** A large buffer allows for quicker printouts.
- ✓ **PAPER FEED METHOD:** Friction Feed as well as Tractor Feed should be supported. In Friction Feed, the printer pulls in a sheet from a stack of paper as and when needed. The Tractor Feed mechanism has spokes that fit into the perforations on either side of the paper, and the paper consists of a continuous sheet that can be torn at fixed lengths. Opt for printers that have Top, Bottom and Rear feeding.
- ✓ **AUTOSHARE (ALSO CALLED AUTOSWITCH-**

ING): Some printers with both serial and parallel interfaces can be connected to two PCs simultaneously. The printer senses the PC that is sending data, and switches to the corresponding port. This feature, called AutoShare, is not standard on all printers.

- ✓ **LANGUAGE PRINTING CAPABILITIES:** Dot matrix printers are capable of printing in languages other than English. Look for a printer that has the facility to download other language fonts through a flash ROM.
- ✓ **PRINTING CARBON COPIES:** A lever to the side of the printer lets you decide the thickness of the paper. Combining this with a continuous sheet of type 1+1, 1+2, etc. enables you to print more than one copy simultaneously. Here, 1+1, 1+2, etc. indicate that one copy will be the original while there can be more than one carbon copy. Ready stationary to print carbon copies is available in the market.

Ready Reckoner



You Need

To print bills and invoices on A4-size paper

Look for

An 80-column printer



You Need

To print reports, work-sheets, and balance sheets on A3-size paper

Look for

A 136-column printer

EPSON

5. **Slots:** Slots on the paper provide traction.

Do Remember

❗ Never use low quality ink for a refill. This will lower the life of the print head significantly, and the process itself is messy.

❗ Make a rough calculation of the ribbon's replacement over the life of the entire unit before buying a dot matrix printer. Prints in draft mode are economical.

❗ In case you intend using colour ribbons, make sure you buy one that is of good quality. Though a little expensive, they do give you value for money in the long run.

Facts

❗ Change the ribbon as soon as you start to get faded printouts. A new ribbon not only gives good printouts, but also lubricates wires or pins for smooth functioning and increases the life of the printer. Dried-up ink causes undue wear and tear on the individual pins.